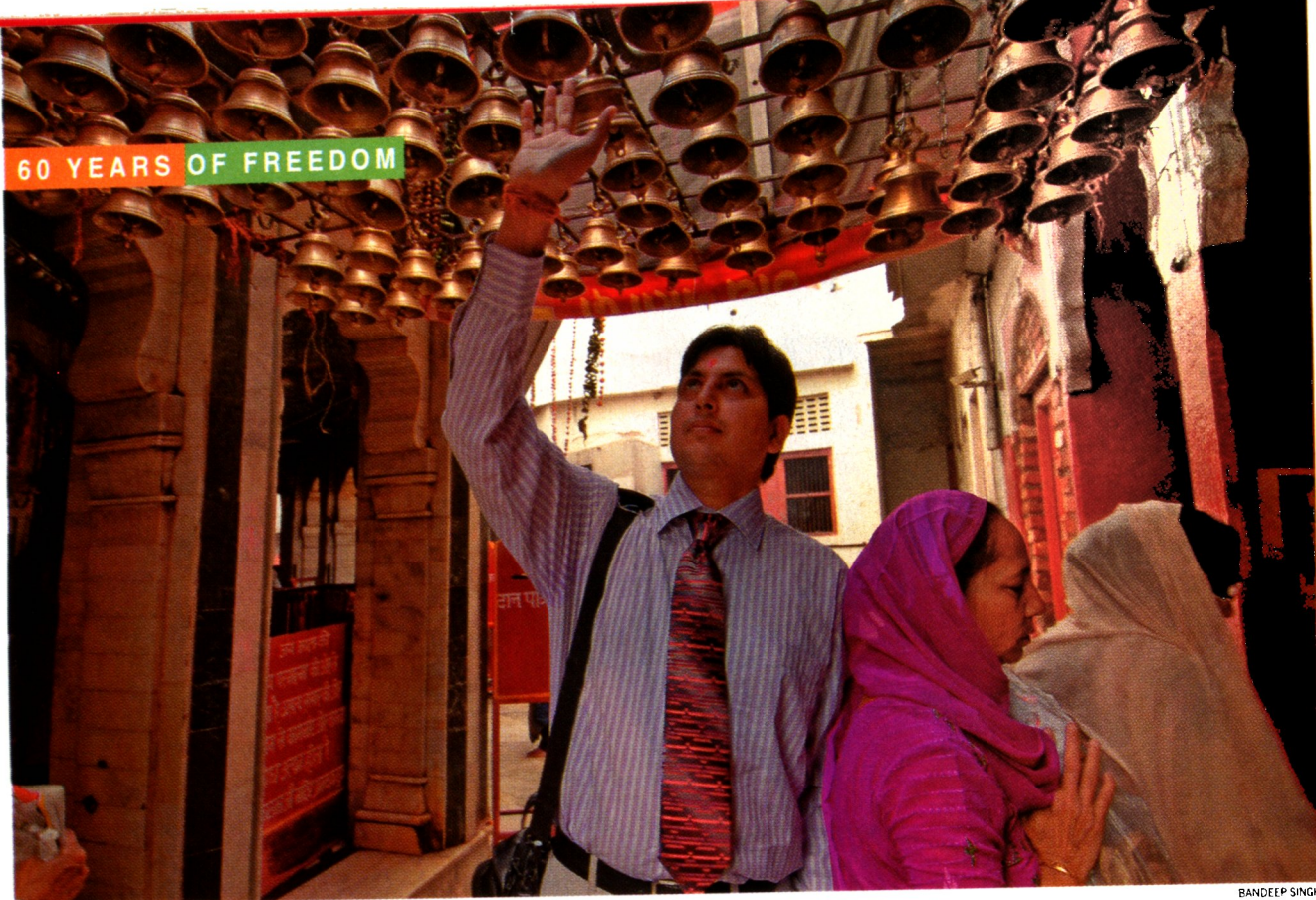




BANDEEP SINGH

Leap of faith

SPIRITUALITY

DELHI

■ By **Chitra Subramanyam**

The beats of the dholak echo in the sanctum sanctorum, in tune with the women who are singing a hymn, their voices drowning out clanging bells and the low incantations of the priests. Ajay Singh, a manager with a private bank, stands near the entrance, his shirt neatly tucked in, tie in place, palms together, lips moving in silent prayer. He moves through the crushing crowd, brushing past women in saris with their heads covered, bodies lying prostrate, and men in dhotis with their foreheads smeared with vermilion. He swings his laptop case across his shoulder and bends down to allow the pundit put a *tilak* on his forehead. Singh moves towards the exit, pausing only to ring the bells strung from the temple ceiling.

Singh doesn't frequent Kalka mandir, this is just his

God is his co-pilot and pilgrimages his way of de-stressing from his busy banking job. The practical Indian, comfortable with his spiritual self, takes time out for worship.

third visit, he says, but for this busy 31-year-old, there's always time for God. On the weekends, he heads to the Iskcon temple right next to his home to sing and dance with the devotees. Sometimes he takes his wife Renu with him, but mostly this is one journey he prefers to make alone or with his younger brother. And at least twice every year, he takes a few days off work and goes on a pilgrimage—to Vaishno Devi, Hardwar, Rishikesh or Shirdi—with family or friends.

Though he isn't much of a drinker, he ensures that he

doesn't consume alcohol or eat meat when on a pilgrimage. It's a ritual Singh is comfortable with. It's his way of de-stressing, he says, of living "a life connected to God, one that runs parallel to my practical life". Often, he finds himself listening to qawwalis, bhajans or sufi music while on his way to work. "I feel energised and ready to begin that day's work," he says. His dream pilgrimage? Amarnath or Kailas Mansarovar. Though one needs a lot of time to visit either temple, Singh is sure he will make it on the back of his faith.

He belongs to the generation of Indians who aren't fettered by confused beliefs. Instead, he wraps his spirituality around him, comfortable in that skin, dealing with the pressures of modern life while answering to the call of his faith with ease.

80.5

IS THE PERCENTAGE OF THE HINDUS IN INDIA. MUSLIMS CONSTITUTE 13.4 PER CENT, FOLLOWED BY CHRISTIANS, BUDDHISTS, SIKHS, JAINS AND OTHERS.